



Making Sense of LINUX

A typical Linux installation is an embarrassment of software choices. We bring order to the chaos

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With more than 3,000 software packages, a GNU/Linux distribution literally opens the floodgates to free software. More often than not, you will find yourself stuck knee-deep in badly-written programs, struggling to cope with frequent crashes.

We took a fine-tooth comb to a SuSE 9.1 Professional distribution, which had everything installed, and separated the good from the bad. Here, we will only stick to KDE and its associated applications.

NOTE: We tried to avoid the KDE menu structure. The idea is to simplify things. To launch a program, click on Run on the KDE menu and type the **command** specified. Note that these commands are case-sensitive.

Konqueror FILE MANAGER

Let's start with the File Manager. Since we are dealing with the KDE environment, Konqueror is the application in charge.

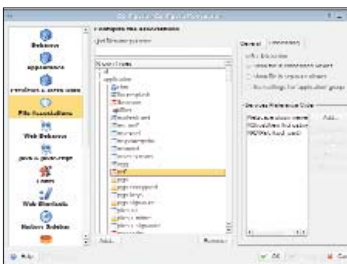
Konqueror can open a bevy of files by default. Text, images, PDFs, icons, movies, audio files... the list goes on.

Konqueror will insist on opening them within its window, instead of launching the associated application. To change this behaviour, click on **Settings > Configure Konqueror**, and click on **File Associations**.

The window on the right will let you change associations or instruct Konqueror not open a file itself. Find this under the tab **Embedding** on the **Left Click Action** pane.

Of course, inbuilt support for

popular formats has its advantages. When you copy something in Konqueror, it can be pasted using the browser itself. So there



You can change the way Konqueror handles files here

is no need to launch a separate application. An example will make it clear.

Say, you have copied a passage of selected text using [Ctrl] + [C]. Next, browse to the destination folder and press [Ctrl] + [V] to paste that text as a new file. You can handle images in the same way. Simply press [Ctrl] + [Print Screen], and do a [Ctrl] + [V] to paste the image as a PNG file.

The best feature of the browser is the **Navigational Panel** on the left of Konqueror. Here, you can frequent favourite locations via the **Bookmarks** tab. To add a folder as a bookmark, press [Ctrl] + [B] while browsing it. You can even browse your local or remote network via the **Network** tab. Interestingly, you can add a Web URL to the Panel. Simply do a right right-click, and go to **Add New > Web SideBar Module**.

Kopete

kopete in Run window
INSTANT MESSENGER

Kopete is the Instant Messenger client for KDE. It supports popular networks such as MSN Mes-

senger, Yahoo! Messenger, ICQ, and IRC. It can even send SMS messages to cell phones. Click on **Settings > Configure Kopete**, then select **Accounts**, and click on **New** to add a new network.

To change Kopete's look to make it look more familiar, click on **Settings > Configure Kopete**, and then on the **Appearance** tab. Here, under the **Chat Window** tab, select the **MSN** style. The **Emoticons** tab lets you select an emoticon set of your choice.

Kopete supports a plug-in architecture. To configure avail-



Giving Kopete a familiar MSN look

able plugins, click on **Settings > Configure Plugins**. You can encrypt your outgoing messages with a personal PGP key. Some interesting plugins are **Auto Replace**, **Highlight**, **History** and **Web Presence**. The last one lets you synchronise your online presence with your personal blog or a Web site.

Desktop Sharing

krfb in Run window

REMOTE DESKTOP CONTROL

Desktop Sharing lets you share your current session under Linux with a user on another machine. The remote user can use a VNC client to view or even control your desktop. This comes in handy for a remote presentation,



Launch applications from the Run command